

Academic Writing

Lesson 1: Making Claims



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

This week we will be looking at ways to improve your writing including:

- Hedging and boosting
 - Passives
 - Nominalisation
 - Concision
- 
- A decorative pixelated pattern at the bottom of the slide, consisting of a grid of squares in various shades of gray and white, arranged in a non-uniform, artistic manner.

1. What is a claim?

- An assertion/argument you make based on evidence

Claims can be **strengthened** (boosted) or made more **cautious** (hedged).

The language you choose should match the relative strength of your evidence.

When to hedge and when to boost



2. These are the results of a survey:

100 Media students, from a cohort of 120, were interviewed and 93 said that they had enjoyed their first term at LSE.

Which claim is more appropriate and why?

- a) This **seems to indicate** that the Media department has, **to some extent at least**, a **relatively** popular programme of courses in the first term.
- b) This **clearly shows** that the Media department has a popular programme of courses in the first term.

When to hedge and when to boost



These are the results of a study:

I conducted interviews with two Chinese students who said they prefer writing in English to speaking.

Which claim is more appropriate and why?

- a) This **proves** that Chinese students prefer writing in English to speaking.
- b) This **suggests** that **that some** Chinese students **may** prefer writing in English to speaking

Claims



There are different degrees of strength available to you when making a claim in the discussion/findings section – do not exaggerate your claim without good reason

VERY STRONG

The above results **prove that...** (not recommended)

STRONG

The above results **clearly show/demonstrate/illustrate that....**

QUITE STRONG

The above results **show/demonstrate/illustrate that..**

QUITE STRONG BUT SOMEWHAT CAUTIOUS

The above results **seem/appear to show/demonstrate/illustrate that...**

QUITE CAUTIOUS

The above results **indicate/suggest that...**

VERY CAUTIOUS

The above results **seem/appear to indicate/suggest that**

On the basis of the above results, **it may/might/could be argued that..**

3. Hedges or Boosters?



Suggest	May	Seem	Appear
Could	Might	Assume	Certain/Certainly
Demonstrate	Plainly	Likely	
Definite/Definitely	Possible/Possibly	Doubtless	
Speculate	Indicate	Probable/Probably	Seemingly
Supposedly	Show that	The fact that	
Substantial/Substantially	Clear/Clearly		
Unmistakable	Evidently	In fact	

Hedges or Boosters?



Suggest

May

Seem

Appear

Could

Might

Assume

Certain/Certainly

Demonstrate

Plainly

Likely

Definite/Definitely

Possible/Possibly

Doubtless

Speculate

Indicate

Probable/Probably

Seemingly

Supposedly

Show that

The fact that

Substantial/Substantially

Clear/Clearly

Unmistakable

Evidently

In fact

Hedges	Boosters
Suggest	Show that
May	Demonstrate
Seem	Fact that
Appear	Substantial/substantially
Could	Clear/clearly
Might	Definite/definitely
Assume	Certain/certainly
Likely	Unmistakable
Possible/possibly	Evidently
Speculate	Plainly
Indicate	In fact
Probable/probably	
Seemingly	
Supposedly	

In addition to verbs, adverbs are often used to indicate attitude and therefore to suggest either hedging or boosting

4. Highlight the claims made in this paragraph



Over the next 25 years, the U.S. economy is likely to experience significant shifts driven by several key factors. Technological advancements, particularly in artificial intelligence, automation, and clean energy, are expected to transform industries, leading to increased productivity but also potential disruptions in the labour market. Demographic changes, including an aging population and shifting immigration patterns, could strain social safety nets and impact workforce dynamics. Climate change and the transition to a more sustainable economy will require substantial investments and may reshape sectors such as energy, agriculture, and infrastructure. Additionally, the global economic landscape will influence U.S. economic policies, as competition with emerging economies, particularly China and India, intensifies. Economic inequality may remain a central challenge, potentially influencing policy debates and social stability. Overall, while the U.S. economy is likely to remain resilient, it will need to navigate these complex challenges to ensure sustained growth and prosperity.

Highlight the claims made in this paragraph



Over the next 25 years, the U.S. economy **is likely to** experience significant shifts driven by several key factors. Technological advancements, particularly in artificial intelligence, automation, and clean energy, **are expected to** transform industries, leading to increased productivity but also potential disruptions in the labour market. Demographic changes, including an aging population and shifting immigration patterns, **could strain** social safety nets and impact workforce dynamics. Climate change and the transition to a more sustainable economy **will require** substantial investments and **may reshape** sectors such as energy, agriculture, and infrastructure. Additionally, the global economic landscape **will influence** U.S. economic policies, as competition with emerging economies, particularly China and India, intensifies. Economic inequality **may remain** a central challenge, **potentially influencing** policy debates and social stability. Overall, while the U.S. economy **is likely to** remain resilient, it **will need** to navigate these complex challenges to ensure sustained growth and prosperity.

5. Can you improve the claims in these sentences?



1. Universities' only purpose is to equip graduates for the workplace.
2. Obviously, universities must increase tuition fees.
3. There is no doubt that social media is extremely damaging to mental health.
4. Social media is fantastic for social cohesion.
5. Gender inequality is evil.
6. No men recognise their historical privilege.
7. Everyone is worried about the fact that there are too many people in the world.
8. Depopulation is a greater concern than overpopulation.

6. Read the text on the following slide and highlight the language that:



- a) Reports ***findings*** from research which the author conducted
- b) Makes ***claims*** based on the research
- c) Uses language to show how **certain** the writer is about her claims ('hedging' and 'boosting')

Task Six



Women reporting high levels of managerial support were less likely to experience strain as a result of work interference with home than were women reporting lower levels of support.¹ This finding supports previous research by O'Driscoll *et al.* (2003),² who found that the effect of work interference with home on psychological strain was moderated by work-home related supervisor support.³ Managers who offer emotional and/or instrumental support for their employees' work-home concerns appear able to reduce the extent to which their subordinates – at least, their female subordinates – suffer strain arising from the interference of work demands with their responsibilities at home.⁴ An employee whose long work hours are interfering with her ability to spend time with friends or family is liable to experience less strain when management appears supportive and willing to help than when management is perceived as uncaring and not interested in employees' lives beyond the workplace.⁵ This effect did not take place for men,⁶ suggesting that they are less responsive to this type of support.⁷ This is perhaps due to gender norms stipulating independence for men, and discouraging them from seeking or accepting assistance from others (Helgeson, 2005).⁸

Example 1



Women reporting high levels of managerial support **were less likely to** experience strain as a result of work interference with home than **were** women reporting lower levels of support.¹

Finding



in past tense, refers
only to women in the
study

If it has been written like this...



Women reporting high levels of managerial support **are less likely to** experience strain as a result of work interference with home than **are** women reporting lower levels of support.¹

Claim



in present tense,
refers to women in
general

Example 2



This finding **supports** previous research by O'Driscoll *et al.* (2003),²

Claim ➡ **Written in the present tense**



Example 3



...who **found** that the effect of work interference with home on psychological strain **was moderated** by work-home related supervisor support.³

Finding



in past tense



Example 4



Managers who **offer** emotional and/or instrumental support for their employees' work-home concerns **appear** able to reduce the extent to which their subordinates – at least, their female subordinates – **suffer** strain arising from the interference of work demands with their responsibilities at home.⁴

Claim → Present simple tense

If it had been written as...



Managers who **offered** emotional and/or instrumental support for their employees' work-home concerns **appeared** able to reduce the extent to which their subordinates – at least, their female subordinates – **suffered** strain arising from the interference of work demands with their responsibilities at home.⁴

Finding ➡ Past simple tense

Example 4



Managers who offer emotional and/or instrumental support for their employees' work-home concerns **appear able to** reduce the extent to which their subordinates – **at least**, their female subordinates - suffer strain arising from the interference of work demands with their responsibilities at home.⁴

Tentative language

Example 4



Contrast:

- Appear able to (tentative claim 'hedging')
- Are able to (strong claim)
- Are clearly able to (very strong claim 'boosting')

Example 5



An employee whose long work hours **are interfering** with her ability to spend time with friends or family **is liable to** experience less strain when management **appears** supportive and willing to help than when management **is perceived as** uncaring and not interested in employees' lives beyond the workplace.⁵

Claim ➡ **Present simple tense**

If it had been written as...



An employee whose long work hours **were interfering** with her ability to spend time with friends or family **was liable to** experience less strain when management **appeared** supportive and willing to help than when management **was perceived as** uncaring and not interested in employees' lives beyond the workplace.⁵

Finding ➡ Past simple tense

Example 5



An employee whose long work hours are interfering with her ability to spend time with friends or family **is liable to experience** less strain when management appears supportive and willing to help than when management is perceived as uncaring and not interested in employees' lives beyond the workplace.⁵

Tentative language = "is likely to"

Example 5



Contrast:

- Is liable to experience (tentative claim 'hedging')
- Will experience (strong claim)
- Will certainly experience (very strong claim 'boosting')

Example 6



This effect **did not** take place for men,⁶

Finding → Past tense, so men
in her study not
men in general.

Example 7



...suggesting that they **are** less responsive to this type of support.⁷

Claim → Present tense, "men generally".



Example 7



...**suggesting** that they are less responsive to this type of support.⁷

Tentative language



Example 7



Contrast:

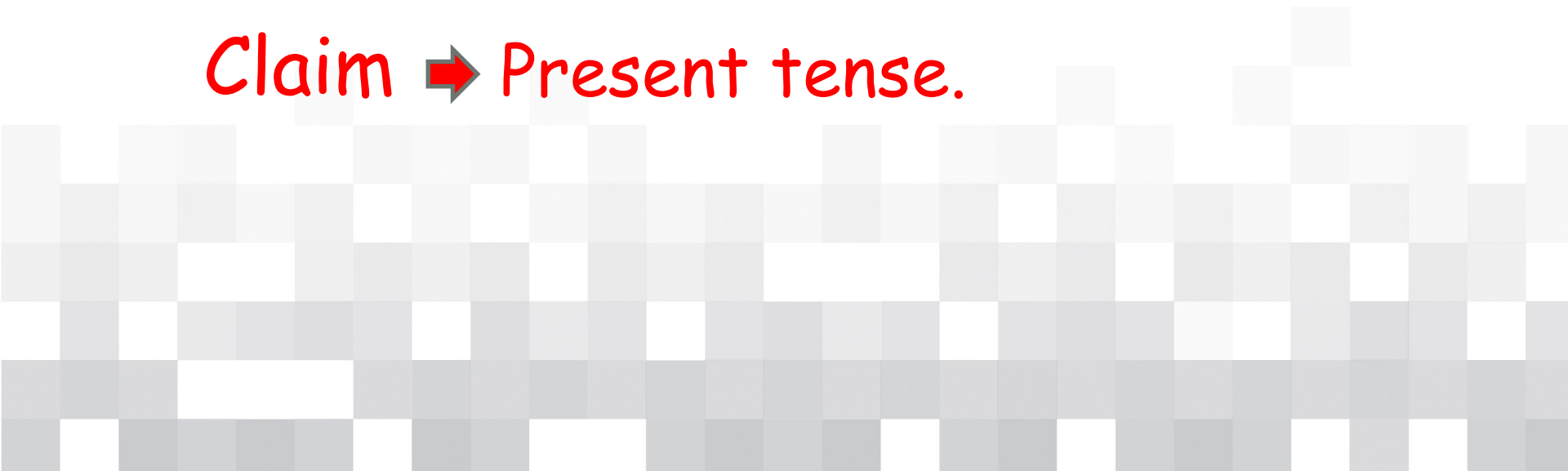
- Suggesting (tentative claim 'hedging')
- Showing (strong claim)
- Proving (very strong claim 'boosting')

Example 8



This **is perhaps** due to gender norms stipulating independence for men, and discouraging them from seeking or accepting assistance from others (Helgeson, 2005).⁸

Claim → Present tense.

A decorative pattern of light gray and white squares, resembling a pixelated or mosaic effect, located at the bottom of the slide.

Example 8



This **is perhaps** due to gender norms stipulating independence for men, and discouraging them from seeking or accepting assistance from others (Helgeson, 2005).⁸

Tentative language.

A decorative pattern at the bottom of the slide consisting of a grid of squares in various shades of gray and white, creating a pixelated or mosaic effect.

Example 8



Contrast:

- Is perhaps (tentative claim 'hedging')
- Is (strong claim)
- Is undoubtedly (very strong claim 'boosting')

Reporting research



When citing previous research, use the **past tense**. Whatever a previous researcher said, did or wrote happened at some specific, definite time in the past and is not still being done.



Interpreting research



When making claims based on research, use the **present tense**. This shows that something applies at the current time and/or emphasises its relevance to the present.



Using cautious language



<http://www.phrasebank.manchester.ac.uk/>



How convincing is this research likely to be?



An external survey conducted by LSE of 1,450 employees in the finance, technology and professional services industries in the UK and USA.

[GENERATIONS: What is the productivity potential of your multigenerational workforce? \(protiviti.com\)](https://www.protiviti.com/generations)

7. What claims could you make based on these findings?



- Across generations, low levels of productivity were reported by 37% of Gen Z, 30% of Millennials, 22% of Gen X, and 14% of Baby Boomers.
- Gen Z had the lowest levels of productivity. (FINDING)
- Gen Z seems to have the lowest levels of productivity. (CLAIM)
- Employees with larger age gaps with their managers reported lower productivity. Those with managers more than 12 years their senior were nearly 1.5 times as likely to report low productivity.
- Generations agreed on the skills that are most important to productivity and career advancement. The top 3 skills being: active listening, time-management and judgement and decision making.

What claims could you make based on these findings?



- In firms that use intergenerationally inclusive work practices, the proportion of Gen Z employees reporting low productivity dropped from 37% to 18%, and from 30% to 13% for Millennials.
- Across the board, 87% of employees reported high productivity levels in firms with intergenerationally-inclusive work practices, compared to just 58% of employees from firms without these practices.
- Employees working at intergenerationally inclusive workplaces were twice as likely to be satisfied with their jobs and were less likely to look for a new role.